

Guideline: What Tests Can Help Find Useful Use Cases

Use cases vary in usefulness for **requirements analysis**. Some are too low-level or too broad. These tests help determine practical and valuable use cases:

Example Candidate Use Cases:

- Negotiate a Supplier Contract
- Handle Returns
- Log In
- Move Piece on Game Board

Focus on the *useful level of description* depending on system boundary, actors, and goals.

Rules of Thumb:

- Boss Test
- EBP (Elementary Business Process) Test
- Size Test

The Boss Test

The Boss Test

Scenario: Your boss asks, “What did you accomplish today?” If your answer is “I was logging in,” the use case fails the Boss Test.

A use case failing this test does not achieve observable or measurable business value. Low-level tasks may still be documented if complex or frequently reused.

The EBP Test

Elementary Business Process (EBP)

A task performed by one person in one place at one time, in response to a business event, which:

- Adds measurable business value
- Leaves the system in a stable and consistent state

Good EBP-level use cases: “Handle Returns,” “Process Sale.” Single steps like “Delete Line Item” or “Print Document” fail this test.

The Size Test

A valid use case typically involves multiple steps in its **main success scenario**. Fully dressed use cases may span 3–10 pages.

Common Mistake

Defining a single small action (e.g., “Enter an Item ID”) as a standalone use case fails the Size Test.

Example: Applying the Tests

Candidate Use Case	Boss Test	EBP Test	Size Test	Comment
Negotiate a Supplier Contract	✗	✗	✗	Too broad; suitable as a <i>business-level</i> use case.
Handle Returns	✓	✓	✓	Good system-level use case; complete and valuable.
Log In	✗	✗	✗	Low-level task; not valuable alone.
Move Piece on Game Board	✗	✗	✗	Too small; single-step activity.

Reasonable Violations of the Tests

Some subfunction-level use cases may fail these tests but are useful for modularity or reuse:

- **Authenticate User** – may fail Boss and EBP tests but is complex enough for separate analysis.
- **Pay by Credit** – reused in multiple use cases; modeled as an *included use case*.

Summary: Rules of Thumb

- **Boss Test:** Achieves measurable business value?
- **EBP Test:** Complete, consistent, single-session task?
- **Size Test:** More than a single step, less than multi-day process?